

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Grace With Hard People

In May, the class had to talk about the hard ones.

"Friends," said Ms. Calloway, "we have done two weeks of the Grace Challenge. You have all been amazing. But I want to talk about something else now."

"What about hard people? What about the people who keep being mean? What about the people who do not change? Do you have to give THEM grace?"

The kids were quiet.

"Here is what I think," said Ms. Calloway. "Grace with hard people is real. But grace with hard people has limits. Grace is not the same as letting somebody hurt you over and over. Grace is not the same as pretending somebody is okay when they are not. Grace is not the same as letting somebody walk all over you."

She held up a chart.

GRACE WITH LIMITS

You CAN: wish them well. Hope they have a good day. Not be mad at them. Be polite when you see them.

You DO NOT HAVE TO: play with them. Be best friends with them. Trust them. Let them hurt you again.

"Grace," said Ms. Calloway, "is internal kindness. It is what is happening inside YOU. Trust, friendship, closeness — those are different things. Those are external. Those are about what

you do with the person. Grace is what you carry in your heart. The two are not the same." Sammy nodded.

"Some people in your life," said Sammy, "are going to be hard. Some people in your family. Some people in your school. Some people you will meet later. You do not have to like everybody. You do not have to be best friends with everybody. You do not have to invite everybody over for your birthday."

"But you can — if you want to, and only if you want to — choose grace in your own heart. You can decide, privately, I wish them well, even though I am not going to play with them. You can decide, I hope they have a good day, even though I am not their friend. That is grace with limits."

"And friends — listen — you NEVER have to choose grace. Grace is always a choice. It is not a rule. If somebody is hurting you, you protect yourself FIRST. You tell a trusted adult FIRST. You stay safe FIRST. Grace comes much later, if it comes at all. Safety always comes first." Kezia, in the back, was nodding.

The class did a quiet activity. Each kid wrote down — privately, in their journal — the name of a person who was hard for them. (Some kids wrote a family member. Some wrote a kid in another class. Some wrote a kid in their own class. Theo, who was watching everybody, wrote a name we never see, because Theo's journal stays Theo's.)

Then they wrote one sentence next to the name.

The sentence was a grace with limits sentence. It went like this: I do not have to _____. But I can wish them _____.

Marcus wrote: I do not have to play with Vincent every day. (Marcus had not stopped finding Vincent's sandwich habits weird, even though Jordan had stopped making fun.) But I can wish him well.

Kezia wrote: I do not have to let the grown-up come over. But I can wish them peace.

Priya wrote a list, because of course she did. I do not have to invite Mrs. Patterson to my birthday party (she is not invited, no offense, Mrs. Patterson). But I can wish her a quiet day at the library.

Amara wrote: I do not have to be friends with the kids at my old school who never asked how to say my name. But I can wish them — actually I do not wish them anything yet. That is okay too.

(That is also okay. Amara is not yet ready. That is fine. The teacher knows.)

Maya wrote: I do not have to talk to my mom every week. But I can wish that she is okay, wherever she is.

Each kid wrote one sentence. Ten sentences of grace with limits. None of them got read aloud. None of them got read by anybody. They just got written, and put in journals, and closed.

That night, ten kids went home with a thought in their head they had not had two months ago: I do not have to like everybody. I can wish them well anyway. Both can be true.

Most adults never get this thought. Most adults think they have to either love a person or hate a person — be friends or enemies — invite them over or freeze them out. The middle ground — the I wish you well from a long way away place — is a place most adults never find. The kids of Room 12 found it in May. Of first grade. With Sammy on a hand.

That is what this whole book has been for.